THE UNIVERSITY OF CHICAGO
HARRIS SCHOOL OF PUBLIC POLICY

CONFLICT & DEMINING POLICY IN COLOMBIA

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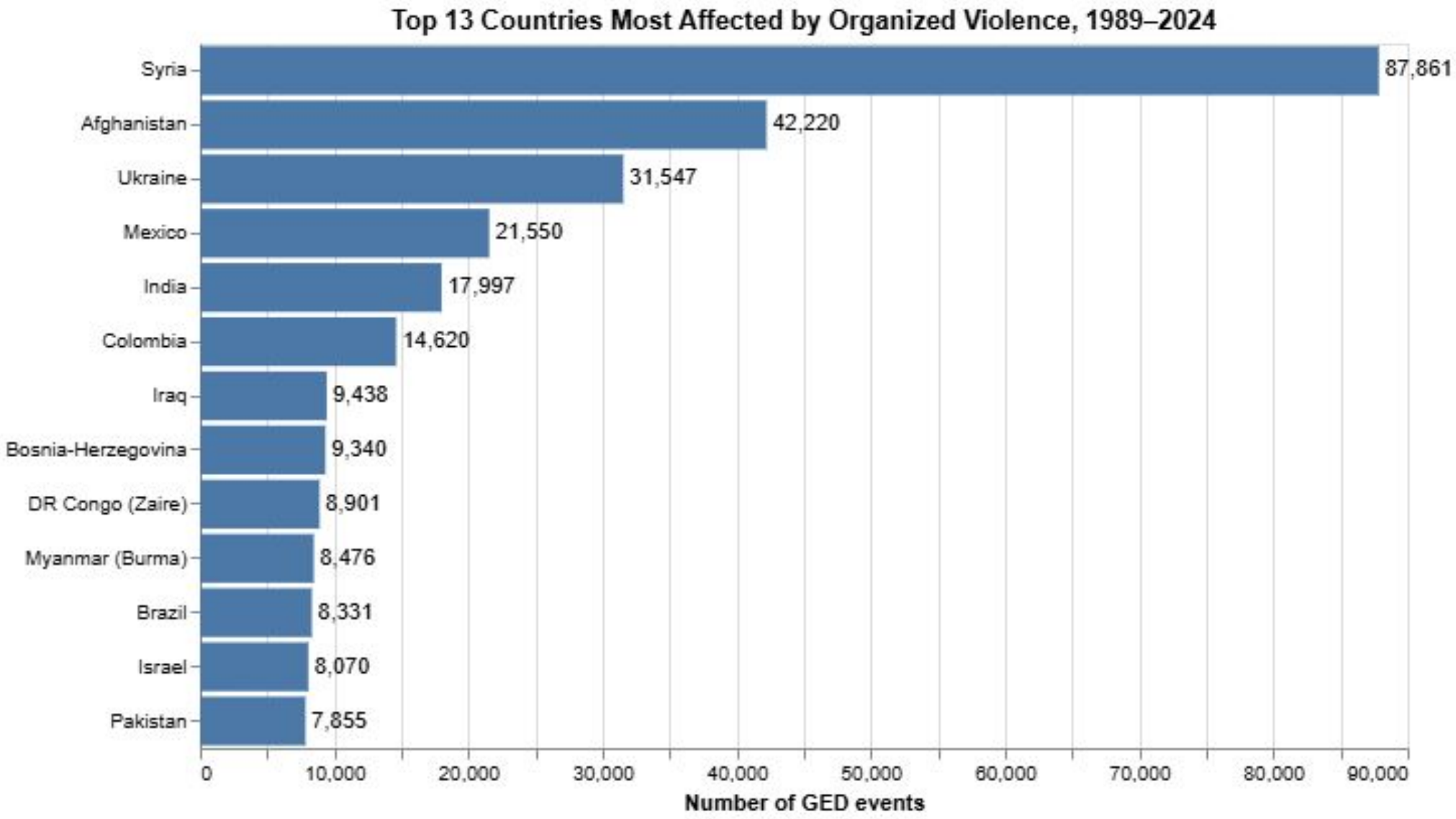
AGENDA

- 1. Armed conflict and landmine contamination in Colombia
- 2. Research questions and data
- 3. Spatial distribution of conflict and landmines incidents
- 4. The 2016 Peace Agreement and demining policy
- 5. A data-driven prioritization framework

CONFLICT IN COLOMBIA

- Located in South America, borders with Venezuela, Peru, Ecuador and Brazil.
- Colombia has experienced prolonged armed conflict.
- Ranks among the countries with the highest number of recorded conflict events, according to the UCDP Georeferenced Event Dataset (GED).
- An event in GED is defined as a **single instance of organized violence where at least one fatality occurs** and where one of the actors is a state, non-state armed group, or organized armed actor


Top 13 Countries Most Affected by Organized Violence, 1989–2024
Syria
87,861
Afghanistan
42,220
Ukraine
31,547
Mexico
21,550
India
17,997
Colombia
14,620
Iraq
9,438
Bosnia-Herzegovina
9,340
DR Congo (Zaire)
8,901
Myanmar (Burma)
8,476
Brazil
8,331
Israel
8,070
Pakistan
7,855
0
10,000
20,000
30,000
40,000
50,000
60,000
70,000
80,000
90,000
Number of GED events

LANDMINES IN COLOMBIA

- Beyond conflict events, Colombia has a specific territorial feature: extensive antipersonnel landmine contamination.

- What is a landmine? A landmine is an explosive device placed on or under the ground that detonates when a person or vehicle triggers it.

- By 2018, it was estimated to be among the top 10 countries worldwide with the highest number of victims of antipersonnel mines (MAP) and explosive remnants of war (MUSE) (Landmine Monitor, 2018).

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

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1. Are conflict events and landmine incidents spatially correlated at the municipal level?

2. Has post-2016 demining policy targeted the most affected municipalities?

- **Goal**: Build a data-driven prioritization tool for demining policy allocation

DATA

UPPSALA UNIVERSITET

UCDP Georeferenced Event Dataset (GED), Global Version

This dataset provides highly disaggregated, geo-coded data on individual events of organized violence, including exact locations and dates. It enables spatial and temporal analysis of conflict intensity and distribution.

Observatorio de Memoria y Conflicto

Centro Nacional de Memoria Histórica

National Center for Historical Memory, Observatory of Conflict & Memory.

Public national database: *Conflicto Armado en Cifras* — recorded landmine and explosive device incidents, 1953–2025.

DASHBOARD

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STREAMLIT APP:

https://final-project-alesofjua-mdp47eu4ptjr5t3dxsek7v.streamlit.app/

PEACE AGREEMENT AND DEMINING POLICY

- The 2016 Peace Agreement marked a policy shift: it institutionalized demining policy.

- Demining activity increases sharply after 2016, reflecting policy prioritization and discovery.

- Demining increases economic growth by:
  - Enabling access to essential infrastructure and new markets (Chiovelli, Michalopoulos, & Papaioannou, 2019).
  - Opening opportunities for the use and productive exploitation of natural resources (Gunawardana, Tantrigoda, & Kumara, 2016).
  - Facilitating the development of productive activities, and supports land restitution processes (Cabrera & Pachón, 2017).

POLICY RECOMMENDATION & CONCLUSION

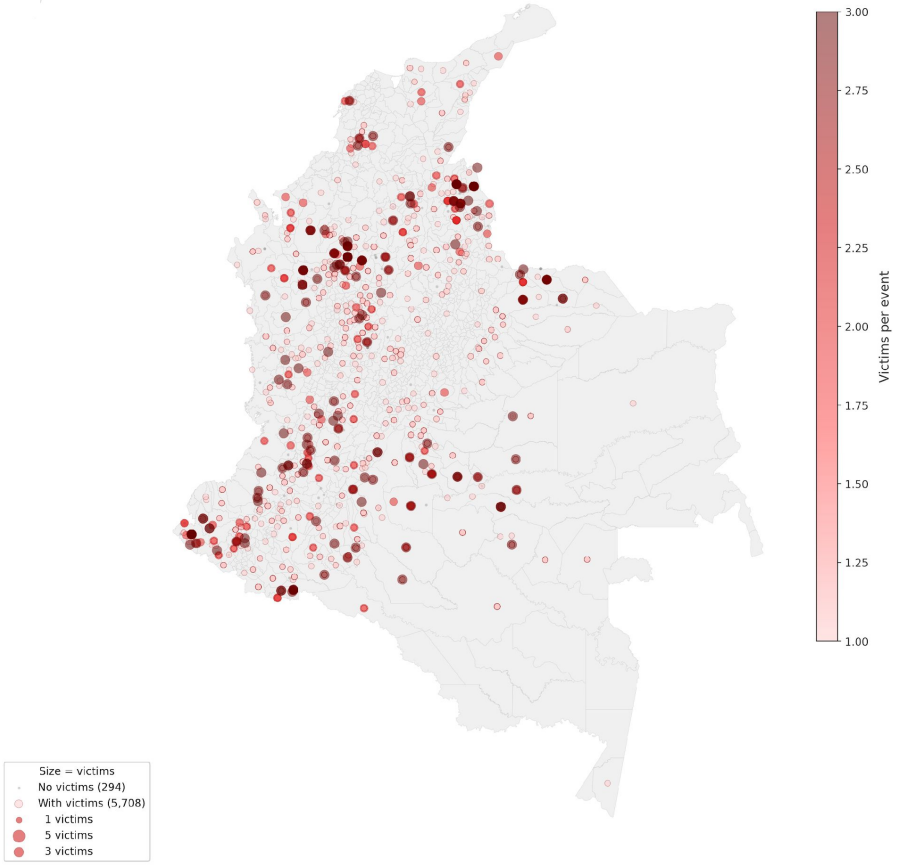
- The purpose of this project is to serve as a practical tool that offers a descriptive prioritization framework for policymakers, rather than to establish causal relationships.
- We construct a simple difference-based prioritization index at the municipality level.
- The gap equals total landmine incidents minus total demining operations.
- Large positive values indicate potentially under-served municipalities

QUESTIONS?

APPENDIX – ADDITIONAL CHARTS

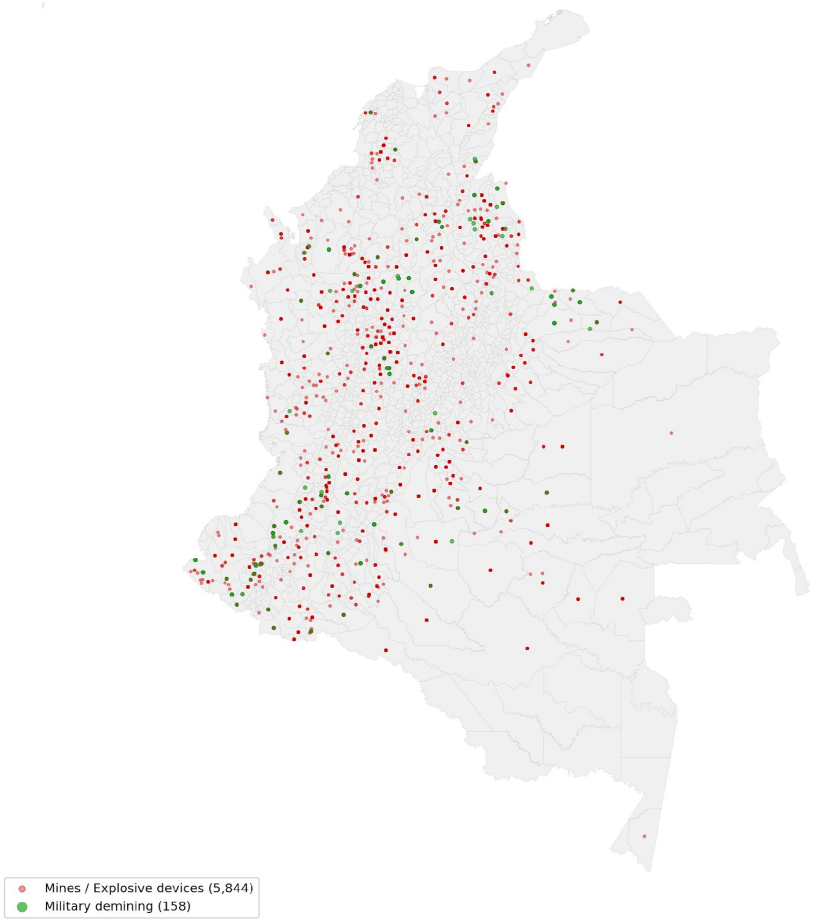
APA

Antipersonnel Mines: Location and Victim Intensity
Colombia 1994–2024 (CasosMI)



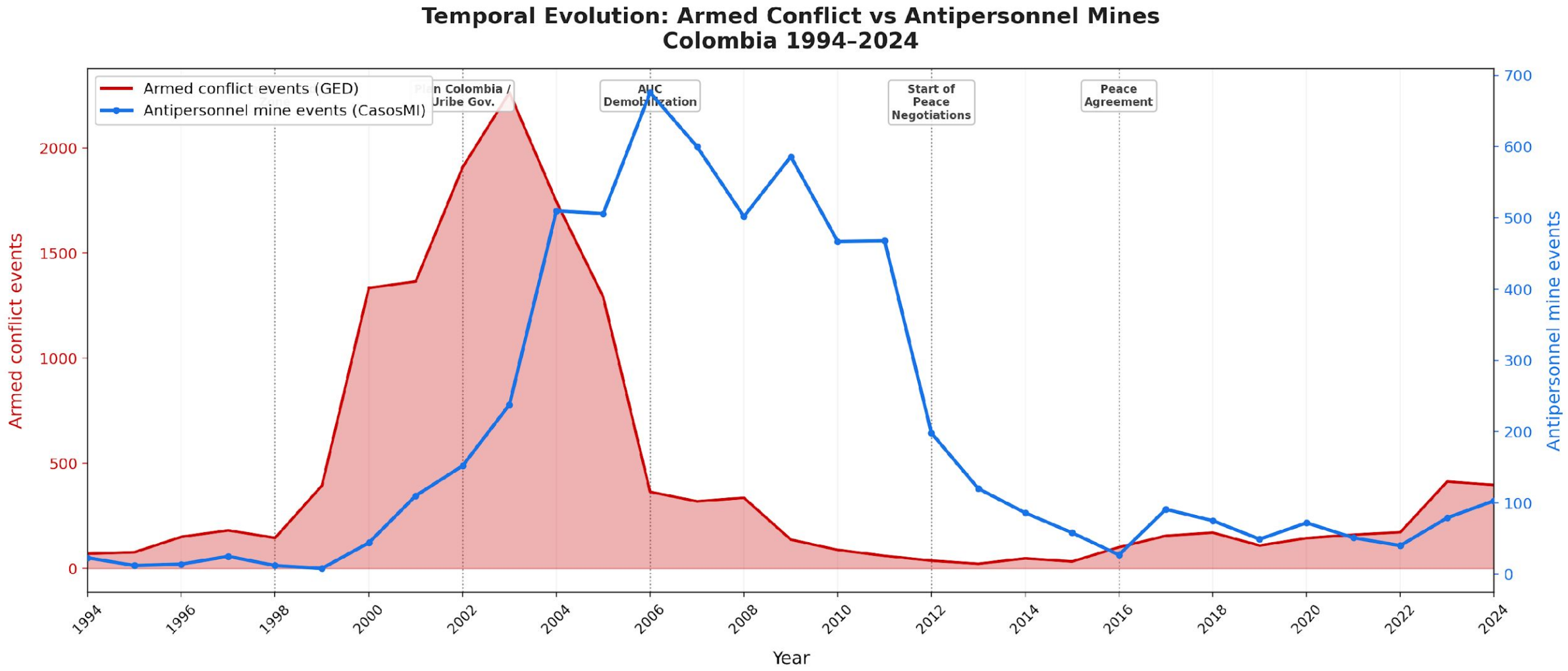
Total events: 6,002 | Total victims: 6,443 | Source: Descontamina Colombia – CasosMI

Antipersonnel Mines by Municipality
Colombia 1994–2024 (CasosMI)



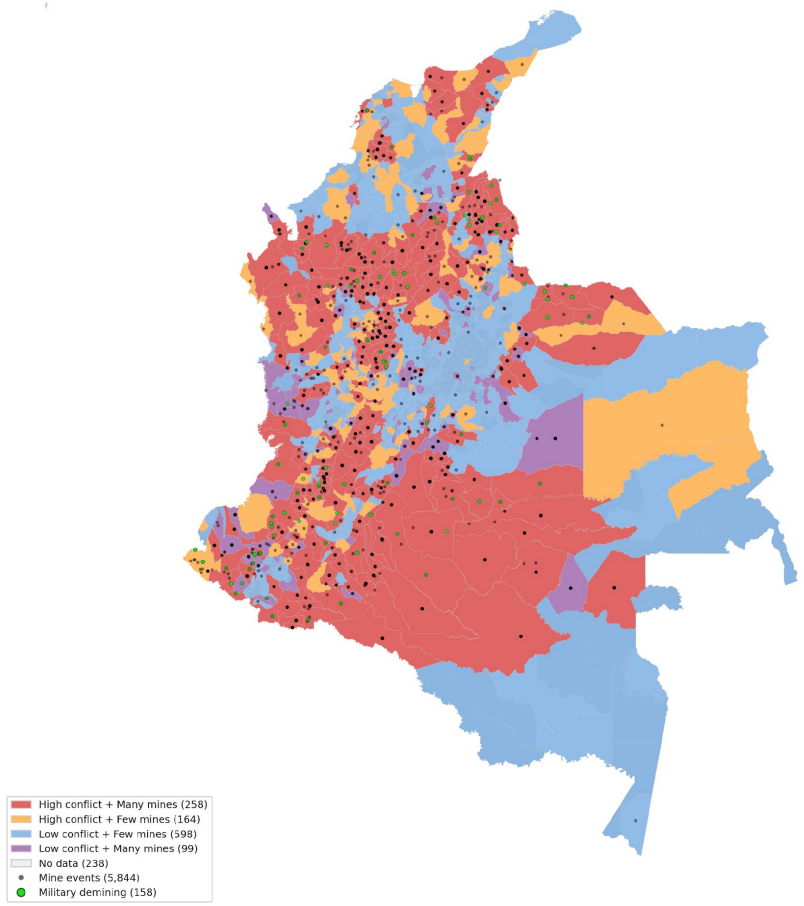
Total events: 6,002 | Source: Descontamina Colombia – CasosMI

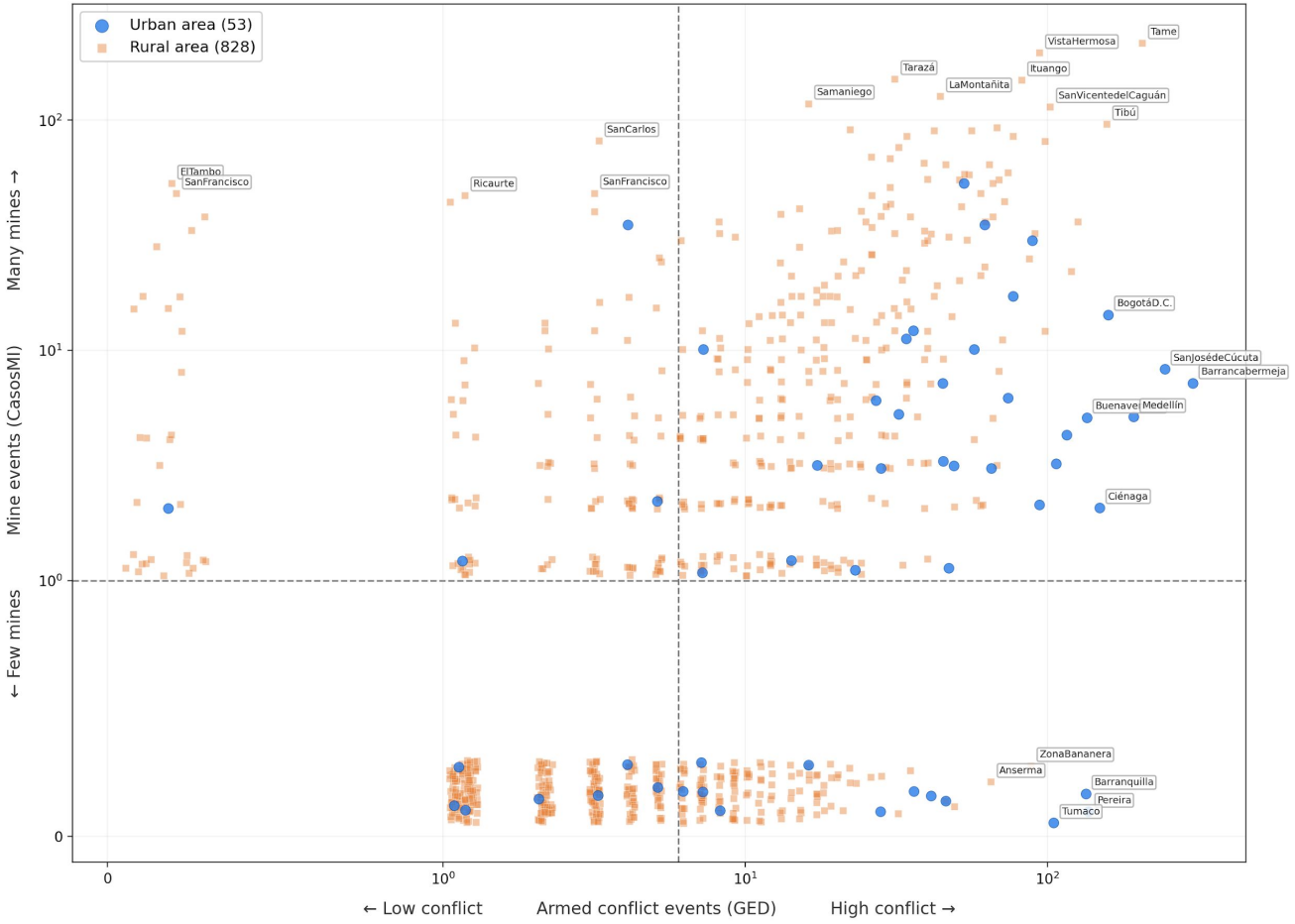
APA


Temporal Evolution: Armed Conflict vs Antipersonnel Mines
Colombia 1994–2024
Armed conflict events (GED)
Antipersonnel mine events (CasosMI)
n Colombia /
Uribe Gov.
AUC
Demobilization
Start of
Peace
Negotiations
Peace
Agreement
Armed conflict events
Antipersonnel mine events
Year
0
500
1000
1500
2000
0
100
200
300
400
500
600
700
1994
1996
1998
2000
2002
2004
2006
2008
2010
2012
2014
2016
2018
2020
2022
2024

APA

Municipality Classification with Mine Locations
Colombia 1994–2024



Sources: UCDP GED v25.1 + Descontamina Colombia (CasosMI) | Cutoff: conflict > 6, mines > 1

Armed Conflict vs Antipersonnel Mines by Municipality
Colombia 1994–2024